

## Teaching Philosophy Statement

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When people name those who shaped their lives most, teachers come up more often than almost anyone besides parents and close friends. A good teacher can be a turning point; a poor one can demotivate even the most interested student. I know this firsthand: I was finishing my master's degree in economics, headed for a career in consulting, when a professor inspired me to try academia instead. That encounter set the course of my professional life.

The rise of artificial intelligence has only raised the stakes of that conviction. Explaining concepts is no longer the scarce resource. AI can explain most ideas brilliantly, instantly, and endlessly. What it cannot do is what good teaching has always centered on. It cannot motivate the student who has stopped believing the work matters, and it cannot teach attitude and love of the subject, the curiosity, persistence and honesty that a teacher transmits by example. AI cannot design the experience of doing real research rather than reading about it; it cannot notice who in the room is struggling and step in with tailored, individual support. If anything, the teacher's role has grown. In the ocean of instantly available information, students need someone who leads, who models judgment about what is worth knowing and what to do with it. Students need a teacher who knows them and cares.

The principles that follow are my answer to what a teacher must be in this new era. I teach my students to use new tools critically, creatively, and honestly. And I help them build the confidence and skills no tool can substitute: asking good questions, evaluating evidence, and producing original work they can stand behind. These convictions come from experience. I have taught for more than fifteen years across two countries and two disciplines. As an Associate Professor at Kyiv-Mohyla Academy in Ukraine, I taught Introductory Econometrics, Public Finance, and International Taxation and mentored student research. After returning to graduate study, I completed my PhD in Developmental Psychology at the University of Pittsburgh in 2026, where I taught Developmental Psychology and Research Methods as instructor of record and served as teaching assistant for Biopsychology, Learning and Motivation, and Research Methods Lab between 2018 and 2024, earning the department's Advanced Achievement in the Teaching of Psychology certificate and its program award.

Teaching across such different systems, subjects, student populations, and formats – in person, hybrid, and fully online – has convinced me that no single approach fits every classroom. But it has also distilled five principles that travel with me everywhere I teach.

1. **Know seven times more than you teach.** A teacher needs to know far more than any lecture requires, because the best moments in a classroom can't be scripted. To illustrate, a student's question turns the discussion towards unexpected territory, and teaching comes alive if the instructor has the depth to follow with a real example instead of a deflection. I build my courses to create opportunities for such moments. In Developmental Psychology, students read original research, question its methods and conclusions, and apply the

developmental perspective – how constancy, change, sensitive periods, and the timing of experiences shape development from conception into young adulthood. In Research Methods, students pose genuine research questions, design experiments, analyze their own data, and write full scientific reports. I guide them through the whole arc, from question to written finding, drawing on my own years of research in the lab and in policy settings.

2. **Knowledge becomes meaningful when it is useful.** Mastering a subject requires motivation beyond the grade. Developmental science offers this naturally: my students connect theories of development to the children and adolescents in their own lives, and to themselves, as future teachers, parents, practitioners, and citizens. This principle holds even in more technical subjects: in my econometrics courses, I build assignments around real data and business cases that students carry into their research and job interviews. When students see what the material is for, they push through the inevitable hard parts.
3. **Care is what makes high expectations fair.** Kindness without standards produces slacking; standards without kindness produce fear; and the essence of a teaching craft is holding both. This became vividly clear when I taught through the COVID-19 pandemic. I surveyed my students on their wellbeing, and a large majority reported high or very high stress, not from the course, but from the upheaval surrounding all of us: isolation, illness in families, disrupted lives. Knowing what my students were carrying changed how I taught: when office hours didn't work for a struggling student, I found time that did. I joined Zoom five minutes before class and stayed ten minutes after to check in with students on their health and wellbeing. But support is not softness, and a warm classroom must never signal that less is expected. Even fully remote, mid-pandemic, my students designed real studies and wrote full reports to a standard I did not lower, though I stayed flexible about the path each student took to reach it.
4. **Know who is in the room.** Every class is a different combination of individuals, and their lives outside the classroom are not equal. The pandemic made this visible: the same disruption fell unevenly (crowded homes, unreliable internet, sick or newly unemployed parents), though all students were held to the same expectations. As a researcher who studies how family economic circumstances shape development, I was watching the disparities I study reshape learning in my own classroom. The experience deepened my commitment to equitable, inclusive teaching, and that lens stays with me in every course: flexible paths to the same standards, and attention to the students whose obstacles are invisible.
5. **Sharpen the saw.** A teacher bored by their own course cannot make students curious about it. I refresh my courses with current research, new readings, and updated examples. The same curiosity that drives my research keeps my teaching alive: to be interesting to students, I must stay interested myself.

These principles are not universal laws. Teaching is a craft, and mine continues to evolve, never more than now, when what students need from a teacher is changing faster than at any point in my fifteen years. What doesn't change is the core: real work, attention, and a teacher who cares. That is the classroom I build, wherever I teach.